

Activity 4: What Do You Need to Know More About?

Hepatitis A, B, and C are different.

2.1.3 Hepatitis A

Hepatitis A is a viral disease that affects the liver. Anyone can be infected with hepatitis A if they come in direct contact with food, drinks or objects contaminated by the faeces (poo) of an infected person. There have been outbreaks associated with eating contaminated shellfish, and among particular groups including injecting drug users and gay men. Hepatitis A is also common in developing countries where hygiene standards are poor.

Outbreaks have also occurred in childcare centres.

This is because children under three years of age often don't show any symptoms but can infect childcare workers or other children, especially if care is not taken during nappy changing.

Hepatitis A, B & C are different

One attack of hepatitis A will give you lifelong protection. However, remember that hepatitis A, hepatitis B and hepatitis C are caused by different viruses. This means that prior infection with one type won't offer any immunity against the others.

It takes time for the symptoms to show

You can fall ill any time between 15 and 50 days after catching the virus, with the average incubation period being 28 days. Many infected people, show few or no symptoms. For older children and adults, the symptoms include:

- Fever
- Nausea
- Abdominal discomfort
- Dark urine
- Yellow skin and eyes (jaundice).

The disease is infectious

Hepatitis A is caused by a virus. It is spread when taken by mouth, which can happen when hands, foods or other items are contaminated with the faeces from a person with hepatitis A. The disease can also be spread sexually by oral-anal contact. A person with hepatitis A is infectious from two weeks prior to showing symptoms, to one week after they become jaundiced.

Strict hygiene is important

To reduce your risk of catching hepatitis A, you should:

- Wash your hands with soap and hot running water before handling food, after going to the toilet and after handling used condoms or having contact with the anal area of another person.
- Clean bathrooms and toilets often, paying attention to toilet seats, handles, taps and nappy change tables.
- Boil your drinking water if it comes from an untreated source, such as a river.

You can be immunised against Hepatitis A

Immunisation against hepatitis A includes a course of injections over six to 12 months. Hepatitis A immunisation is a good idea for people travelling to places where the disease is common. The vaccine is also recommended for childcare workers, gay men, people with liver problems, food handlers, injecting drug users and some other groups.

Type of help available

Hepatitis A can be diagnosed with a blood test. There is no specific treatment, but your doctor can help prevent the disease from spreading to other family members by offering them an injection of immunoglobulin.

Things to remember

- Hepatitis A is a viral disease that affects the liver.
- Hepatitis A, hepatitis B and hepatitis C are caused by different viruses so catching one doesn't offer immunity against the others.
- Children under three years of age often don't show symptoms.

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2.1.4 Hepatitis B

There are several viruses that can cause hepatitis (inflammation of the liver) and each virus is known by a particular letter in the alphabet, such as hepatitis B. All of the viruses cause similar problems, but they are spread in different ways.

Symptoms of hepatitis B

The symptoms vary of hepatitis B vary. They include:

- Loss of appetite, nausea and vomiting.
- Pain in the liver - this is felt under the right hand side of the ribcage.
- Fever and pain in the joints.
- Jaundice - the urine becomes darker and the eyes and skin turn yellow.
- Tiredness.
- Carriers can spread the virus even if they are not sick

Carriers of hepatitis B:

- Often show no symptoms
- Can infect others, even when they look and feel well
- May eventually develop liver cancer or chronic liver disease.
- Babies and children are more likely than adults to become carriers.

How hepatitis B is spread

Hepatitis B can be spread by:

- Having sex without a condom
- Sharing needles, syringes and other injecting equipment
- Sharing razor blades and toothbrushes
- Body piercing and tattooing the skin with improperly cleaned and sterilised equipment
- Infected blood coming into contact with the open cuts of an uninfected person.
- Hepatitis B can be passed from mothers who are carriers to a baby in the womb or during the birth. Immunisation at birth will protect these babies from the disease.
- In about 30 to 40 per cent of cases, infections occur without a known cause.

Avoiding hepatitis B

To protect against hepatitis B:

- Get immunised.
- Use condoms for vaginal or anal sex.
- Do not get friends to do your body piercing or tattooing. Go to a professional tattooist or piercing studio.
- Oral sex is normally unlikely to spread hepatitis B, but it is best to avoid oral sex if you or your partner have herpes, ulcers or bleeding gums.
- Do not share needles, syringes or other equipment (such as spoons, swabs and water) if you inject drugs.
- Wear disposable gloves when cleaning up blood or administering first aid.

If you think you have been exposed to hepatitis B, see your doctor immediately. You can be given treatments that may greatly reduce the risk of hepatitis B infection.

You can be immunised against hepatitis B

You need three injections to be fully immunised:

- The first two injections are given one month apart.
- The third injection is given five months after the second dose.
- Side-effects are uncommon, but can occur soon after immunisation. They include fever, injection site soreness, nausea and joint pain.

Things to remember

- Hepatitis B can cause serious illness or death.
- Body piercing and tattooing are a risk for Hepatitis B, especially if done by a non-professional.
- Carriers can spread the virus, even if they look and feel well.
- Immunisation is 95 per cent effective.

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2.1.5 Hepatitis C

Hepatitis C is a blood-borne virus that causes inflammation of the liver. It is most often transmitted through sharing needles, syringes and other equipment during drug use. There is currently no cure for hepatitis C and no vaccine to prevent it, however, there are ways to alleviate the symptoms and drug therapy is successful for some people.

How people become infected by hepatitis C

A range of activities can lead to hepatitis C. Most people in Australia are infected by sharing drug injecting equipment. An increased risk of hepatitis C is also associated with:

- Tattooing and body piercing using unsterilised equipment.
- Sharing razor blades or toothbrushes.
- Health care work where there is exposure to blood.
- Kidney dialysis.
- Blood transfusions given before 1990.

Activities with a low risk of infection

There is a low risk of infection from:

- Sexual intercourse. (The risk may be greater if there is bleeding, for example, during menstruation.)
- Blood transfusions given since 1990.
- Transfer from mother to baby during pregnancy, at the time of birth or during breastfeeding.

Symptoms can be mild

People with hepatitis C may show only mild, flu-like symptoms, or no symptoms at all. Symptoms that do appear include:

- Dark-coloured urine
- Jaundice - when skin and the whites of the eyes go yellow.
- If you have these symptoms, see your doctor, who will give you a blood test for hepatitis C. It may not show up until two or three months after you were originally infected.

Hepatitis C often becomes chronic

When the initial infection persists for more than six months, it is called chronic hepatitis C. Symptoms of chronic hepatitis C include:

- Mild to severe tiredness
- Loss of appetite
- Nausea and vomiting
- Soreness in the upper right side of the stomach (under the ribs)
- Fever
- Joint pain.

Most people infected become carriers for life

More than 70 per cent of people infected with hepatitis C continue to carry the virus in their blood. These people have an increased risk of developing cirrhosis (scarring) of the liver and some will develop liver cancer. They can also infect other people at any time.

How to avoid catching hepatitis C

There is currently no vaccine to protect people against hepatitis C. Everyone should take the following steps to help protect themselves:

- Avoid sharing personal items such as toothbrushes, razors, nail files or nail scissors, which can carry blood.
- Go to professionals for tattooing or piercing. Do not get friends to do it.
- Use 'safe sex' practices, including condoms for vaginal, anal and oral sex.

There is no vaccine for Hepatitis C.

If a person injects drugs they should:

- Never share drug injecting equipment such as needles, syringes, tourniquets, spoons, swabs and water.
- Always wash their hands before and after injecting have any contact with blood.

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Treatment for hepatitis C is limited

People who have hepatitis C will feel better if they:

- Avoid drinking alcohol
- Eat a well-balanced, low fat diet
- Rest when tired
- Consult their doctor regularly.

Hepatitis C can be treated with drug therapy. However, the success of drug therapy depends on many factors and treatment does not benefit everyone. Side effects are common.

Things to remember

- Hepatitis C is hard to treat and easy to spread.
- There is no vaccine for hepatitis C.
- Hepatitis C could be transmitted by unsafe piercing and tattooing practices.
- See your doctor immediately if you have any symptoms.

The information is based on that available through the Better Health Channel,
(www.betterhealth.vic.gov.au/)